



Feted in New York

President Diem enjoys a tickertape parade through New York City on a state visit to America in May 1957. The South Vietnamese leader was greeted with enthusiasm as the man who had saved his country from communism.

Overthrow

Officers in the South Vietnamese forces (ARVN) loathed the rule of Diem's family and his secret police. He was lucky to survive an air attack on the presidential palace by his own air force in 1962. Diem's favoritism toward Catholics further destabilized his regime, while the Buddhist Crisis had a catastrophic effect on US opinion—especially when Madame Nhu spoke out to mock the martyrdom of Buddhist protester Thich Quang Duc. The US had hoped that Diem would be a bulwark against communism. Now seeing him as a liability, they chose to support an ARVN coup. Diem was ousted on November 1, 1963. Captured as they fled, Diem and his brother Nhu were assassinated on November 2—bayoneted and shot in the back of an armored vehicle.

“[I] want now to do what **duty and good sense** require. I believe in **duty above all.**”

NGO DINH DIEM'S LAST PHONE CALL TO US AMBASSADOR HENRY CABOT LODGE,
NOVEMBER 1, 1963